

[Return to Search](#)

Libyan politics

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The General Assembly in Kufra

Ajdabiyans and Kufrans argued successfully, by fair and foul means, and variously supported and subverted their revolution. Huaiwiri got its girls on the path to education, but in Kufra no cadre expropriated a landlord or socialized a business. In Ajdabiya, closer to government, with a more heterogeneous population, the effects of revolution were more obvious. But to the men of Kufra whose fathers or grandfathers had settled there because it was so centrally placed on trade routes, or because it was so remote from Ottoman, Italian or British control, 'central government' appeared indeed as a real force, but as one located — so to speak — in the extreme northwestern corner, in Tripoli.

[634
Districts](#)[668
Political Movements](#)

The outcome of revolution, therefore, was a product of negotiation and discussion among Kufrans rather than a simple consequence of revolutionary decrees. In some cases the inspiration from Tripoli created opportunities which coincided with the interests and enthusiasms of men like Salah Muhammad who then set about persuading people, one by one, to take advantage of them. In other cases, the decrees seemed to provide an opportunity for insurance against other possible future decrees. But in all cases the revolution was filtered by discussion — those long, intermittent, laconic, joking conversations in shops and in guestrooms of private houses. Of course people did discuss public matters in public. But the more public settings, events, demanded other styles, other kinds of reticence than these. People hid their self-interest more closely when speaking before relative strangers; they sometimes also feared reprisals and so censored their opinions.

[634
Districts](#)[668
Political Movements](#)

In 1978 the Kufra Assembly met for a couple of hours each evening for a week. The meetings were in the playground of the Bu Bakr school in the central settlement, Zawiya. A  170 colonnade along the west side above a raised pathway provided a sheltered dais for the chairmen of the popular committees who sat behind a table with two or three microphones. In front of them stood a microphone on a stand, and then several rows of school chairs filling about a third of the area, though most people sat on the ground. Boy scouts attended, serving bottles of Greek orangeade to the participants. At the entrance was a table for a member of the local Assembly executive who checked people's names and wrote down their identity card numbers as they came in. The number of participants varied from evening to evening: attendance was higher at the beginning of the week than at the end. And in the course of each evening numbers rose from a dozen or so to a hundred, and then diminished as people wandered away to supper. No women attended, and only a handful of Tibbu. Isa, the chairman of the local Assembly executive committee, began proceedings at about 5.30 p.m.; at sunset the audience moved to the east end of the playground and, the glowing sky colouring their white clothes, said their prayers; at about 7.30 Isa adjourned the meeting.

634
Districts

668
Political Movements

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